

A Thin Veiled Night

Little Gap

writer: d.b.j

EXT. CAMPFIRE RING / BLUE MOUNTAIN ABOVE LITTLE GAP - NIGHT

Split oak waits on the stone lip of the ring. Pines stand close on the ridge side, tall enough that their trunks could pass for standing men if the flame dropped low. A melted blue plastic fork sits half-buried in the ash at the ring's edge, left by whoever rented the cabin the week before.

NARRATOR (grown, years after that overnight) sits near the heat. Across the ring, a few youth faces wait with marshmallow sticks. MR. KOVACS sits on a stump with a dented thermos between his boots and a folding rule in his shirt pocket.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Hand me that split oak. The pines on this side of Blue Mountain stand so tall and close you could mistake them for men if the fire got low and you weren't careful. I want the light high before I tell this one, because this one is about tall ones who really walked, and about a boy who had to decide what to do with his feet when they did.

Narrator feeds the oak toward the coals. Flame climbs a little. Kovacs screws the thermos lid down with his thumb.

A KID across the ring laughs and says the giants in Genesis were metaphors. Another kid says they were cartoons for people who hadn't got science yet. Narrator keeps their mouth shut, because their grandfather had told a different story every deer season since Narrator was nine.

MR. KOVACS

They weren't metaphors.

He says it the way a man says a rafter is out of square.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

I was fourteen the October my church youth group overnighted in

a rented cabin above Little Gap,
up where the Appalachian Trail
cuts the ridge and the wind comes
hard off the Lehigh. Our youth
pastor's father came along to keep
the stove lit and the boys from
wrestling through the drywall. His
name was Mr. Kovacs. He had worked
roofs in the Slate Belt until his
knees quit. That first night he
sat on that stump and listened to
us talk, then he told us what his
own father had told him, which is
the way these things travel when
nobody writes them down careful.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRE-FLOOD SETTLEMENT / RIVER VALLEY - DUSK

Timber and mudbrick houses sit in a wide valley. Cypress
chips and clay dust mark the paths. ADON (12) digs tubers
behind his house. Red clay packs under his fingernails.

Without any thunder the sky turns white. Down the valley
comes a smell like struck metal.

Out of the white comes a figure shaped like a man. He is
beautiful the way a blade is, and he stands a head and more
taller than Adon's father. This is a Watcher. He asks leave
at no door. He walks straight into a widow's house at the
settlement's edge.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

In the days when men multiplied on
the earth, long before any of our
mountains had names, there lived a
boy called Adon. His father cut
wood under contract for a man
named Noah. Adon's mother kept a
garden of onions and bitter
greens, and she braided Adon's
sister's hair with red clay worked
into the ends so the plaits held.
Adon was twelve the year he first

understood that the tall shining
ones who came down at dusk were
not visitors from a friendly court.

EXT. SETTLEMENT EDGE - DAWN

The widow's door stands open. Neighbors keep clear of it
for three days. The widow is gone.

INT. ADON'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Supper bowls sit on a low table. FATHER comes in with pitch
on his forearms. MOTHER sets a spoon down. SISTER sits with
red clay worked into the ends of her braids.

FATHER

The sons of God left their post.

He keeps his eyes on the bowl.

FATHER (CONT'D)

They were set to watch over us.
They wanted the daughters instead.
We call it what it is. Theft. And
what they breed will not be ours.

MOTHER

People say they're a blessing.
People say the children will be
mighty.

FATHER

People say a lot of things while
the roof is still on.

He wipes his hands on a rag and does not finish his supper.

EXT. MARKET STREET - DAY (TWO YEARS LATER)

Adon is fourteen now and can see over the grain sacks. A
YOUNG GIANT walks the stalls, already as tall as a grown
man. His hands hang large and wrong at the wrists. Dogs put
their tails down when he laughs. Men call him renown. Men
call him a gift.

A copper bracelet lies in the mud. The young giant steps on it and flattens it without looking down, the way you'd flatten a leaf. Adon slips his own hand into his pocket and holds the little bark knife his father gave him.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Years went that way. More of the shining ones came down. More women left and came back carrying what they carried, or did not come back. The children of those unions grew into giants, and the giants grew hungry, and the hunger turned mean.

EXT. STRIPPED FIELDS / SETTLEMENT OUTSKIRTS - DAY

Fields that once fed a generation sit bare to the dirt. Smoke hangs over a broken fence post. Somewhere past the houses, wood cracks and a man shouts once. Adon hears it from the path and keeps walking.

Far off, Noah's hammer keeps time against timber.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Fields that had fed a settlement for a generation were stripped in a week. Men who argued were broken. Violence filled the earth the way floodwater fills a low street, quiet at the edges and then everywhere at once. Through all of it, Noah's hammer kept time.

EXT. NOAH'S YARD - DAY

The vessel rises on braced timber staging, taller than the meeting house and longer than the market street. Men move along its ribs like ants on a beam. Adon (now 15) walks in beside Father. NOAH'S SONS boil black pitch in iron pots and brush it into seams.

A bee sits stuck in pitch on a low plank near the ladder, wings frozen. Adon watches that bee longer than he needs to, because the bee is easier than the size of Noah's work.

NOAH works on a scaffold, older than Adon's grandfather. He preaches while he works, and he does not preach pretty. Scoffers lean on the fence and laugh.

NOAH

The Lord gave this earth a hundred
and twenty years to turn around.
The years are running. Anybody
with ears can hear the clock in
every hammer blow. The Lord is
grieved down to His heart. All
flesh has corrupted its way.

He looks past the scoffers to the men who still have pitch on their hands.

NOAH (CONT'D)

You can laugh, or you can pick up
a tool.

Father picks up a tool every morning. Mother packs them bread and onions and does not laugh, and does not come to the yard either.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

She had a sister who had gone with
one of the shining ones in the
second year and had sent back word
once, proud, about a son who could
already break a plow handle in his
fists, and then had sent no word
at all.

Adon takes a brush and a pot. He works pitch into a seam a man shows him.

EXT. SETTLEMENT DOORPOSTS - DAY

Old men scratch the hundred-and-twenty count on doorposts. Children learn the marks the way children learn the names of rivers. Adon walks past a post where the scratches have nearly filled the wood from top to bottom.

INT. ADON'S SLEEPING SHELF - NIGHT

Adon's thumb runs over scratches on the underside of the shelf, one scratch a season. The marks sit closer together than they did the year before. He ties his sandals in the dark and goes to work.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Pity never drove a peg.

EXT. SETTLEMENT WELL - EVENING (LAST HANDFUL OF YEARS)

Adon and Sister stand at the well. Through the settlement comes a GIANT hunting grain that is already gone. His head clears the eaves. He carries a peeled sapling for a spear, the bronze head beaten as wide as a platter.

GIANT

Where are the stores.

HEADMAN

The stores are empty.

The giant drives the spear butt through the headman's door and walks in to check for himself.

Sister makes a sound and starts toward her own door. Adon catches her wrist.

ADON

To the yard. Now.

They run as somebody screams behind them and wood breaks. A heavy body comes up empty on grain and decides to be angry about it. Adon does not look back. Sister's wrist is in his grip, the bark knife in his pocket, and on his tongue the Name Father taught him for when his feet want to stop.

ADON

(under his breath, on the
path)

Lord God. Lord God.

EXT. NOAH'S FENCE / YARD - NIGHT

They hit the fence in full dark. Noah's sons hang pitch lamps along the near rib. Farther down the holding pens, animals shift restless, two by two where they were led. Father is up on a scaffold with a mallet. He spots them, drops the ladder without a question, puts Sister behind him, and clamps Adon's shoulder hard enough to hurt.

FATHER

Inside the gate. Both of you.

INT. NOAH'S YARD / ROPE COIL - NIGHT

Adon sleeps against a rope coil that smells of tar and river water. Sister sleeps with her head on Father's knee. Outside the gate the valley stays quiet a long while. The giant never reaches the yard.

EXT. NOAH'S GATE / PATH - MORNING

Smoke hangs over the settlement. Mother comes up the path carrying a wrapped bundle, a cut on her forearm she refuses to explain. She walks through Noah's gate and does not look back at the valley.

EXT. NOAH'S YARD - MIDDAY

Noah comes on them with pitch in his beard. He studies Adon the way a builder studies a timber, checking whether the load will hold.

NOAH

You ran the right direction. Most don't.

MOTHER

Will you take us.

Her voice comes out rough.

NOAH

The Lord told me who comes through that door when the time arrives. Until then, anybody who will work and repent can stand in this yard

and hear the truth. After the door
shuts, the count is over.

Father goes back up the scaffold. Adon takes a brush and a
pot and works pitch into a seam until his wrist aches.

EXT. NOAH'S FENCE - DAY

SCOFFERS crowd the fence and holler that Noah has lost his
mind, and that the tall ones will guard the valley better
than any wooden box. One of them fathered a boy by a woman
taken and returned, and that boy is already famous across
three settlements for what he can lift. The father shouts
the boy's name like a cheer. Adon stays on the seam with
his mouth shut and his hand moving.

EXT. NOAH'S SCAFFOLD - MORNING (COUNT NEARLY OUT)

Again the sky goes white with no thunder. Adon stands on
the scaffold beside Father. Where the road comes into the
far edge of the settlement, THREE WATCHERS wait. Even from
here Adon knows them: fathers of giants, Watchers who left
their proper domain, standing in stolen flesh that fits
them too well. No wave. No call. Those three size up the
vessel the way a man measures a fence he means to deal with
later.

Father puts his mallet down.

FATHER

Inside.

ADON

They're not coming this hour.

FATHER

Inside anyway.

INT. NOAH'S VESSEL / GREAT DOOR - CONTINUOUS

They go in. Noah stands at the great door with his hand on
the frame. The fear is not on him. He stands like a man who
already knows the weather coming and has built for it.
Behind him, in the dim, animals shift and grumble. Sister

stands with her back against a crate of seed grain. Mother stands with her.

NOAH

(not loud; to the three on
the road)

In the name of the Lord who shut
and who opens, you will not have
this yard.

Outside, the three Watchers hold still a long time. Then they turn and go back into the white that brought them.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

That is the part my grandfather
always told twice. It was as if a
door in the air had been claimed
by somebody with a better key.

EXT. NOAH'S YARD - DAY (RAIN BEGINS)

A new smell arrives first. The north goes dark, and rain comes down harder than anyone alive has seen, because that world used to take its water a different way and no living man had watched the sky open like this. Deep places under the valley break. Adon stands in Noah's yard with pitch still on his hands. He watches the settlement's roofs disappear under weather the valley has never carried. He looks up the ribs of the vessel.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMPFIRE RING / BLUE MOUNTAIN - NIGHT (BACK TO FRAME)

Mr. Kovacs stops the story there on purpose. He picks up his thermos. Up above the cabin the pines stand black against what little stars they have, and for a minute they look again like men standing watch.

MR. KOVACS

The Book names eight souls. It
does not name Adon. A wise teller
leaves the knife on that stone and
does not pretend he knows the
rest. What I know is simpler. Tall

ones walked in real bodies.
Watchers left their post on
purpose. Giants ate and broke and
made the earth unfit, and the Lord
gave time, and then He gave water.
A boy who ran toward the yard
instead of toward the famous names
was doing the one kind of brave
that still matters when the ridge
goes dark.

Narrator feeds the oak until the fire catches and the light
climbs. The pines are only pines again.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
I was fourteen. I walked back to
the cabin with my flashlight on
the roots so I wouldn't turn an
ankle, and I did not tell the
others that my grandfather's
version and Mr. Kovacs's version
had the same bones.

INT. RENTED CABIN / TOP BUNK - NIGHT

Narrator (14) climbs into a top bunk under a quilt that
smells like mothballs and woodsmoke. Once in the night
Narrator wakes and hears the wind moving in those pines.
Narrator names the Lord the way Adon named Him on the path,
then sleeps again.

EXT. CAMPFIRE RING / BLUE MOUNTAIN - NIGHT (GROWN CODA)

Narrator (grown) builds the fire up. A few kids across the
ring still call giants a metaphor when they want to sound
grown. Narrator lets them finish.

NARRATOR (V.O.)
I still come up here when I can.
The cabin rents to anybody now,
and the Trail still cuts the
ridge. Kids still say giants are a
metaphor when they want to sound
grown. I let them finish. Then I
build the fire up and I tell it

straight. The veil gets thin in places people stop expecting. Watchers left their domain once already, and Scripture says they are kept for judgment. Earth has been through one cleansing of that particular evil, and Jesus said the days of Noah would look familiar again before the end. Under a pine I'll only say this: the tall ones walked, a hammer kept time, and a boy ran the right direction with his sister's wrist in his hand.

Narrator looks at the unspent oak on the stone lip.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Go on. Put that other oak on. I like these pines better when the fire's high enough to show me they're trees.

FADE OUT.